

NARRATION

1 Direct Speech and Indirect Speech

One day Ram met Mohan. Ram asked Mohan where he was going. Mohan replied, “I am going to my uncle's house.”

There are two ways in which Ram can report this.

1. Mohan said, “I am going to my uncle's house.”
2. Mohan said that he was going to his uncle's house.

In the first way Ram uses the actual words spoken by Mohan. For this purpose, he uses inverted commas [“ ”] after the Reporting verb *said*.

In the second way, Ram gives the substance of what Mohan had said.

The first way of reporting is called Direct Speech or Direct Narration.

The second way of reporting is called indirect speech or Indirect Narration.

Before going further, note the following grammatical terms:

Sita said to me, “I cannot do this exercise today.”

Reporting Verb- Reported Speech

The verb of the Reporting Speech is called the Reporting Verb. Here the reporting verb is *said*. The following points must be noted:

- (i) The actual words of the speaker are put within inverted commas.
- (ii) There is a comma before the Reported Speech begins.
- (iii) The Reported Speech begins with a capital letter.

2 Changing Declarative Sentences into Indirect Speech

Study the following examples:

1. Direct : My brother says, “I cannot do this sum.”
Indirect : My brother says that he cannot do this sum.
2. Direct : Baljeet Said, “I cannot do this sum.”
Indirect : Baljeet said that he could not do that sum.
3. Direct : They said to us, “We will help you tomorrow.”
Indirect : They told us that they would help us the next day.
4. Direct : The teacher said to me, “I am very busy now.”
Indirect : The teacher told me that she was very busy then.

Note the following points in respect of the Indirect Speech:

1. No inverted commas are used.
2. No comma is used to separate Reported Speech from Reporting Verb.
3. A Conjunction (that) is used after Reporting Verb.
4. In most cases, tense of the Reported Speech changes into the corresponding past tense.
5. Pronouns and possessive adjectives undergo some changes.
6. If the Reported Speech is in past tense, words showing *nearness* are changed into words showing *distance*.

3. Rules Regarding Change of Tenses:

Rule 1 : If the Reporting Verb is in present tense or future tense. the tense of the Reported Speech does not change.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : Mother says, "Tea is ready."
Indirect : Mother says that tea is ready.
2. *Direct* : Asha will say, "The sum was difficult."
Indirect : Asha will say that the sum was difficult.
3. *Direct* : Ram will say to you, "I am honest."
Indirect : Ram will tell you that he is honest.
4. *Direct* : Your friend will say to you, "It rains heavily in Shillong."
Indirect : Your friend will tell you that it rains heavily in Shillong.

Rule II

If the Reporting Verb is in past tense and the Reported Speech is in present tense, it changes into its corresponding past tense. Thus,

Present Indefinite	changes into	Past Indefinite
Present Continuous	changes into	Past Continuous
Present Perfect	changes into	Past Perfect
Present Perfect Continuous	changes into	Past Perfect Continuous

Under the same condition,

Past Indefinite changes into Past Perfect.

Past Continuous changes into Past Perfect Continuous.

Can changes into could

May " " might

Shall " " should

Will " " would

Note : Past Perfect and Past Perfect Continuous tenses do not change.

Rule III

If the Reported Speech expresses some universal truth, religious truth, historical truth or a proverbial truth, its tense undergoes no change:

Examples :

1. *Direct* : The teacher said, "Two and three make five."
Indirect : The teacher said that two and three make five.
2. *Direct* : The preacher said, "Love is God."
Indirect : The preacher said that Love is God.
3. *Direct* : My father said, "Man proposes, God disposes."
Indirect : My father said that Man proposes, God disposes.
4. *Direct* : Mother said, "The Second World War ended in 1945."
Indirect : Mother said that the Second World War ended in 1945.

4. Rules Concerning change of Pronouns and Possessive adjectives :

Rule 1 : Pronouns of the first person in the Reported Speech change according to the Subject of Reporting Verb.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : My sister said to me, "I do not want to waste my time."
Indirect : My sister told me that *she* did not want to waste *her* time.

Rule 2 : Pronouns of the Second Person change according to the *object* of Reporting Verb.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : I said to her, "You should do *your* work."
Indirect : I told her that she should do *her* work.

Rule 3 : In the case of pronouns of the 3rd person, there is *No change*.

More Examples :

1. *Direct* : Asha said to me, "He is wasting his time."
Indirect : Asha told me that he was wasting his time.
2. *Direct* : The teacher said to me, "You should not disturb him."
Indirect : The teacher told me that I should not disturb him.
3. *Direct* : You said to me, "You are not my friend."
Indirect : You told me that I was not your friend.

Nearness – Distance Rule : If the Reporting Verb is in Past Tense, words showing nearness are changed into words showing *distance*. Thus :

<i>Now</i>	<i>change into then</i>
<i>This</i>	" " <i>that</i>
<i>These</i>	" " <i>those</i>

Today		<i>changes into that day</i>
Tonight	" "	<i>that night</i>
Tomorrow	" "	<i>the next day</i>
Yesterday	" "	<i>the previous day</i>
<i>or</i>		
		<i>the day before</i>
Last night	" "	<i>the previous night</i>
Here	" "	<i>there</i>
Hither	" "	<i>thither</i>
Ago	" "	<i>before</i>
Thus	" "	<i>so</i>
Hence	" "	<i>thence</i>
Next week	" "	<i>the following week</i>
Next day	" "	<i>the following day</i>

Note : Nearness - Distance Rule applies only if the Reporting Verb is in Past Tense.
If the Reporting Verb is *not* in Past tense, this rule does not apply.

Examples :

- Direct** : Ram said, "I cannot help you now."
Indirect : Ram said that he could not help me then.
- Direct** : My brother says, "I cannot help you now."
Indirect : My brother says that he cannot help me now.
- Direct** : They said to me, "Mohan will do his work tomorrow."
Indirect : They told me that Mohan would do his work the next day.
- Direct** : He says to me, "Mohan will read this story tomorrow."
Indirect : He tells me that Mohan will read this story tomorrow.

5 Changing Imperative Sentences into Indirect Speech :

In order to change Imperative Sentences into Indirect Speech, proceed as follows :

- Change Reporting Verb into request/requested, beg/begged, order/ ordered, command/ commanded, advise/ advised according to the sense of the Reported Speech.
- Change the verb of Reported speech into
to + v₁ (First form of the verb)
Or
not to + v₁ (First form of the verb)

Examples :

- Direct** : The master said to the servant, "Bring me a new flower today."
Indirect : The master *ordered* the servant to bring him a new flower that day.

2. *Direct* : The doctor said to the patient, "Eat fresh oranges and don't sit in the sun."
Indirect : The doctor *advised* the patient to eat fresh oranges and not to sit in the sun.
3. *Direct* : The beggar woman said to us, "Please buy me a meal."
Indirect : The *beggar* woman begged us to buy her a meal.
4. *Direct* : The captain said, "Soldiers, don't attack the enemy until the rain stops."
Indirect : The captain *commanded* the soldiers not to attack the enemy until the rain stopped.

Use of 'Let' in Imperative Sentences

'Let' can be used in several ways as follows:

- (i) To make a proposal : In such a case, Reporting Verb is changed into propose/suggest and let is changed into should.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : She said to us, "Let us play hide-and-seek."
Indirect : She proposed to us that we should play hide and seek.
2. *Direct* : Raju said to his friend, "Let us go out for a picnic."
Indirect : Raju proposed to his friends that they should go out for a picnic.

- (ii) To permit or persuade : In such cases, let is changed into to let or might be allowed to.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : Rani said to her father, "Let me marry the boy I like."
Indirect : Rani asked her father to let her marry the boy she liked.

Or

Rani suggested her father that she might be allowed to marry the boy she liked.

2. *Direct* : The teacher said, "Let him go home."
Indirect : The teacher suggested that he might be allowed to go home.

- (iii) To express a condition or supposition: In such a case, let is changed into might.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : He said, "Let her try ever so hard, she will not win."
Indirect : He said that she would not win however hard she might try.

Interrogative Sentences

There are *two types* of interrogative sentences :

- (a) Sentences beginning with a word like *What, When, Why, Where* etc.
- (b) Sentences beginning with some helping verb like : *Do, Does, Is, Am, Are, Was, Were, Has, Have, Had, Can, Could, Should, May, Might* etc.

Rules to be followed while changing the Interrogative sentences into the direct form of narration :

1. Use 'if' or 'whether' as conjunction to introduce the reported speech in sentences belonging to type (b) above.
2. Change the reporting verb 'say' into 'ask' 'enquire' or 'demand'. etc.
3. Change the *question form* into *assertive form* and remove the sign of interrogation (?).
4. Do not use any conjunction to introduce the reported speech in sentences belonging to type (a) above.
5. The conjunction 'that' is not to be used to introduce the reported speech in any case.

Examples :

1. *Direct* : I said to him, "When are you coming?"
Indirect : I asked him when he was coming.
2. *Direct* : He said, "Where is my mother?"
Indirect : He asked where his mother was.
3. *Direct* : He asked, "Will you serve me faithfully?"
Indirect : He asked him whether he would serve him faithfully.
4. *Direct* : Rattan said to me, "Will I accompany you to Shimla?"
Indirect : Rattan asked me if he would accompany me to Shimla.
5. *Direct* : The daughter said to her mother, "Did you prepare the breakfast?"
Indirect : The daughter asked her mother if she had prepared the breakfast.

Exclamatory and Optative Sentences

Rules :

1. The Optative or Exclamatory form is changed into Assertive form and dealt with accordingly.
2. The Reporting verb is changed into some such verb or expression as 'wish', 'bless' 'pray', 'exclaim', 'declare', 'confess', 'disapprove', 'say in astonishment' etc. with such phrases as 'with regret', 'with delight' or 'with joy', 'with sorrow' where needed.
3. All interjections or interjectional phrases are omitted and a new word or phrase is supplied in the principal clause to express their meaning.
4. The conjunction 'that' is used to introduce the *Reported speech*.
5. All other rules of change of pronouns and tenses are applied.

Remember :

- (a) We wish good morning, good evening, good night etc. and *bid welcome, farewell, good-bye* etc.
- (6) Ho ! Hurrah! Hu! etc. *express* *joy*
 What!Oh! etc. " surprise
 Bravo! Here! etc. " approval
 Alas! etc. " grief or pain

Hark! Hush! Lo! Behold! etc.	”	attention
Pooh! Pshaw! etc.	”	contempt

Examples:

- Direct* : She said, "What a beautiful flower!"

Indirect : She exclaimed that the flower was very beautiful.
- Direct* : I said, "Long live my nephew!"

Indirect : I wished that my nephew might live long.
- Direct* : Mother said, "Alas! I shall never be able to see him again!"

Indirect : Mother exclaimed with sorrow that she would never be able to see him again.
- Direct* : The singer said, "Hurrah! I have won the prize!"

Indirect : The singer exclaimed with joy that she had won the prize.
- Direct* : "What a pity! You have been wasting your life," I said.

Indirect : I regretted that he had been wasting his life.

Exercises for Practice

Exercise 1

Change the following into Indirect Speech :

- He says, "My brother likes apples."
- He says to me, "I do not live here."
- You say to Gagan, "You like English but I like Hindi."
- They say to us, "We are not well today."
- Harpreet Said, "I shall talk to you tomorrow."
- Ram will say, "I have done my work."
- Mohan will say to her, "You can do this thing tonight."
- My sister said to me, "I will visit my friend next week."
- Mrs. Sharma said, "I am teaching my son English."
- The teacher said to us, "Slow and steady wins the race."
- My father said, "Your friend met me yesterday."
- You said to Asha, "You had already done your work."
- My mother said, "I shall go to your school today."
- I said to her, "The English defeated the French in India."
- Mother said to me, "I shall wait for you here."

Exercise 2

Change the following into Indirect Speech :

1. Father said to me, "Mohan was playing while I was reading my newspaper."
2. The man said, "I do not know what to do now."
3. He said, "Two and two make four."
4. "I may not come tomorrow," said Mohan to me.
5. Her brother said, "The sun rises in the East."
6. We said to her, "India won freedom in 1947."
7. The teacher said to us, "I am doing register work."
8. I said, "It has been raining since last week."
9. The teacher said, "If you work hard, you will get a prize."
10. The thief promised, "I will never steal again."

Exercise 3

Change the following into Direct Speech :

1. She told me that she had got a good grade in the examination.
2. Ram promised that he would help me with money.
3. The player said that he was quitting cricket for good.
4. The leader asserted that his party would do anything to uplift the poor.
5. The Principal said that truth wins in the end.
6. My sister said that she could not lift that box.
7. You said that you had not heard the news.
8. They told us that they liked oranges better than bananas.
9. The poor man said that he did not know what to do.
10. The D.C. assured us that he would look into the matter.

Exercise 4

Correct the errors in the following sentences. Write the correct sentences in the space provided:

1. The man asked me what I want.
.....
2. I told to her that Mohan had eaten his lunch.
.....
3. She was telling that she would not eat rice.
.....

4. Ram suggested that let us go for a picnic.
.....
5. The teacher said that two and two made four.
.....
6. My sister asked when I have arrived.
.....
7. I told her wait until Mohan comes back.
.....
8. He told me that the earth moved around the sun.
.....
9. She said that she lives in Ludhiana.
.....
10. I said that she looks very ugly in this dress.
.....

Exercise 5

Fill the empty bubbles in Column C with what was said in Column A as shown in the example:

Example :

- | A | B | C |
|---|--|---|
| <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>You should go to the doctor.
(Speaker)</p> </div> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>What did she say?
(you)</p> </div> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>she advised me to go the doctor. (friend)
(advice)</p> </div> |
| <p>1. Go Away</p> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>What did she say?
(him)</p> </div> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>[order]</p> </div> |
| <p>2. I wish I wasn't so rude to Meena!</p> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>What did she say?</p> </div> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>[regret]</p> </div> |
| <p>3. Don't touch this wire.</p> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>What did she say?
(you)</p> </div> | <div style="border: 1px solid #00a0e3; border-radius: 15px; padding: 10px; width: fit-content; margin: 0 auto;"> <p>[warn]</p> </div> |

- | | | | |
|----|---|-------------------------------|------------|
| 4. | You can do well
in the competition.
Go ahead. | What did
she say?
(you) | [persuade] |
| 5. | I won't go to
the picnic. | what did
she say? | [refuse] |

Exercise 6

Change the following into Indirect Speech :

1. He said to the teacher, "Please do not mark me absent."
2. I said to the driver, "Drive as fast as you can."
3. The teacher said to the students, "Imitate my pronunciation if you want to speak well."
4. The doctor said to me, "Take a cold shower before breakfast if you want to keep fit."
5. She said to me, "Kindly excuse me for coming late this time."
6. Mother said to me, "Never cheat in the examination."
7. Ram said to his friends, "Never tell a lie."
8. The servant said to the master, "Pardon me this time, please."
9. She said to her mother, "Let me join IAF."
10. He said to me, "Let Tinkle try ever so hard, she will not reach the goal."

Exercise 7

Read the following dialogue and report it by filling up the blanks in the paragraph that follows :

- Ram : I have invited three friends to dinner today.
Mohan : It is a very good thing.
Ram : The guests will come at 7 p.m.
Mohan : Then we will have to buy everything before going to office.
Ram : Let's go to the supermarket to buy the things required.

Ram told Mohan that
Mohan replied that
Ram said further that the guests
Mohan replied that then they would
..... Ram suggested that they should
.....

Exercise 8

Read the following dialogue and report it by filling up the blanks in the paragraph that follows :

- Wife : Our servant has run away.
Husband : Is anything missing?
Wife : Yes, my gold watch.
Husband : Where did you keep it?
Wife : On the dressing table, as usual.
Husband : I am going to the police to report.

The wife told her husband that (a)
..... . The husband asked the wife (b)
..... . The wife told
him that (c)
..... . The husband then asked her where she
(d) She replied that
(e)
the husband told her (f)

Exercise 9

Given below you can see a picture. Complete the following paragraph reporting what happened in the picture:



A customer went to a shopkeeper and (a)
..... . The shopkeeper took out one and
told him (b)
..... . The customer told him (c)
..... as it was costly. The
shopkeeper told him (d)
..... .

Exercise 10

Change the Narration :

1. Ram told me that the window went to the hospital because it had panes in its sides.
2. My brother said, "The traffic policeman is the strongest man because he can stop a speeding truck with one hand."
3. She told me that SMILES was the longest word in English because there was a mile between the first S and the last S.
4. The teacher said, "An island and the letter t are alike because they are both in the middle of WATER."
5. She said, "A bald man has no use for keys because he has lost his locks."

Exercise 11

Change the Narration :

1. The teacher told me to do up my buttons.
2. She informed us that the film had already started.
3. The teacher said, "The earth pulls everything towards it."
4. "Shoot the prisoner," said the chief to his men.
5. Maya said, "India became a Republic on 26th January."
6. The doctor advised him to remain away from hurry, worry and curry.
7. He requested me to let him use my scooter.
8. My sister said, "I cannot lift this box."
9. I told my father that I was too young to marry.
10. The police informed us that they had arrested the thief.

Exercise 12

Change the following sentences into the Indirect form of speech:

1. I said to him, "Will you return tomorrow?"
2. She said to me, "Will you come to the party?"
3. She said to the fox, "Are the grape sour?"
4. He said to me, "Do you like sweets?"
5. I said to him, "Do you like apples?"
6. He said to me, "Do you like apples?"
7. I said to him, "Should I depend on you for help?"
8. Rama said to Sohani, "Are you angry with me?"
9. Ritu said to Gurvir, "Are you happy with my performance?"
10. I said to him, "Did you like my new suit?"

Exercise 13

Change the Narration :

1. He said, "May you live long!"
2. He said, "Alas! I have failed."
3. He said, "Would that I were rich!"
4. He said, "Good bye! My friends."
5. He said, "O for a glass of water!"
6. The captain said, "Bravo! A good shot."
7. He said, "Alas! I have been ruined."
8. The old man said, "May God bless you!"
9. "May you prosper!" said my mother to me.
10. "Pooh! Go to hell," said the old lady to her son.

Exercise 14

Change the Narration :

- a. The traveller said, "Can you tell me the way to the nearest inn?" "Yes", said the peasant. "Do you want one in which you can spend the night?" "No", replied the traveller, "I only want a meal."
- b. He said to me, "Hello, is it you? Come in, take a seat. I have heard of your distress. But why do you look so forlorn? I shall do all I can to help you."

Exercise 15

Read the following dialogue :

- Raghav : I think one of my snakes has escaped.
- Sheela : Isn't it dangerous? You really must stop collecting snakes, Raghav.
- Raghav : But I like snakes- they are unusual pets.
- Sheela : But I think it's a dangerous thing to keep such pets.
- Raghav : No, they're not, they are really quite friendly.
- Sheela : Huh! Snakes require a great deal of careful handling and are still a risk.
- Raghav : I don't mind. What matters is that I like them.
- Sheela : Well, quite frankly, I hate them. They are awfully frightening to look at.
- Raghav : Look, I am very careful and I handle them very gently. In fact, I don't have many.
- Sheela : Have you ever been bitten?
- Raghav : Well, its true. I've been bitten once or twice, But

You have overheard this conversation between Raghav and Sheela. Write to your sister Madhu reporting the whole account in your own words. Give the conversation an interesting unexpected or humorous ending.

449/2, Civil Lines

Ludhiana

26th January 20....

Dear Madhu

As I know, you're very interested in Raghav and his snakes. I thought I'd tell you about a conversation I've just heard between him and Sheela.

He told her that he thought one of his snakes had escaped and, as usual, she told him to stop collecting them because they were dangerous (Typical of Sheela! don't you think?)

.....
.....

Yours affectionately

Radha